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DEVELOPMENT

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4.1 INTRODUCTION

In Chapter 3, we explored the Indian concept of self, understanding the intricate relationship between the mind, intellect, and memory, as well as the holistic framework of Panchakosha Vikas. Chapter 4 now takes this understanding further by looking at how children actually grow and develop across various domains like physical, cognitive, socio-emotional, moral, and language, during the Foundational and Preparatory stages. We will also examine the important roles that family, peers, and school play in shaping this development. This Chapter will help you as a teacher to design learning experiences that support children in a holistic and inclusive way.



4.2 LEARNING OUTCOMES

After completion of this chapter, the learner:

- identifies the characteristics and milestones of developmental domains in

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children 3–11 years of age;

- outlines the role of different stakeholders in promoting developmentally appropriate learning;
- designs developmentally appropriate learning activities that promote growth across multiple domains for learners of 3-11 years.

4.3 UNDERSTANDING CHILD DEVELOPMENT AS A HOLISTIC APPROACH

As we begin our journey into understanding the development, let's start with a simple question:

“What helps a child grow into a confident, knowledgeable, and compassionate individual?”

The answer lies in knowing that child development is not a one-dimensional process, it is dynamic and unfolds across multiple interconnected domains that together lead to holistic development. In the following section, we invite you to reflect, observe, and explore the child development (3 to 11 years) journey through the lens of both modern insights and traditional wisdom.

4.3.1 Physical Development

During the initial years, physical development plays a crucial role in enhancing the overall personality. Before moving further, let's observe the following cases:

Case 1	Case 2
<i>“Azaan, an 8-year-old student in Class 3, has been known as an active and cheerful child who participated eagerly in class discussions and group activities. He consistently performed at Class level and had good peer relationships. However, he started showing signs of withdrawal and inattentiveness during lessons. He frequently asked for instructions to be repeated and often gave inappropriate responses, suggesting he had not understood what was said. He became irritable and frustrated, especially during group activities or listening tasks.”</i>	<i>“Parampreet is a 6-year-old child enrolled in a mainstream primary school. Since joining preschool, she has shown strong verbal and cognitive skills. She enjoys storytelling, singing, and interacting with peers. But after few days, she starts facing difficulty in walking and using playground equipment. Her movements are often uncoordinated, and she avoids attending games classes.”</i>



Do the above cases bring your attention towards something inappropriate happening with the child?

To understand it in detail, let us study the regular physical development pattern, with a special focus on children of 3-11 years.

The physical development of children between the ages of 3 - 11 years occurs progressively and includes significant milestones in movement, coordination, strength, and health. The key areas of physical development are:

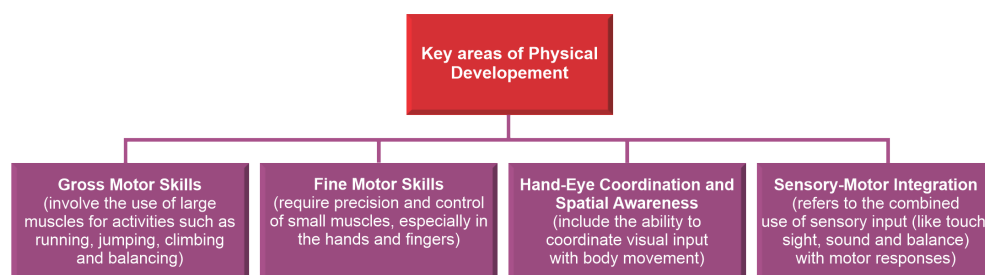


Fig. 4.1: Key areas of Physical Development at the Foundational Stage

There is certain expected behaviour of a child which guides the teacher about child's appropriate physical development and is marked by a predictable sequence of growth and motor skill acquisition that reflects healthy maturation. In early childhood (ages 3–5), children typically show improved balance and coordination, enabling them to run, jump, hop, and climb with greater confidence. Fine motor skills also progress, allowing for activities like drawing shapes, using utensils, and manipulating small objects.

Middle childhood (ages 6–11) is characterized by steady growth in height and weight, increased muscle strength, and refinement of both gross and fine motor skills. Children in this age group usually demonstrate improved agility, endurance, and coordination, which support participation in sports, games, and more complex tasks such as writing fluently and tying shoelaces. Importantly, this developmental stage also includes increased independence in daily activities and a growing understanding of body awareness. Monitoring these milestones helps identify any developmental delays early, ensuring timely interventions when needed.

The NCERT Learning Outcomes Framework and Foundational Literacy and Numeracy (FLN) mission outline several goals for physical development of children aged 3–11 years, each linked to key competencies and engaging activities. The table 4.1 shall help you to understand the key competencies and activities for its enhancement:

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Table 4.1: Goals, Competencies and Activities for Physical Development

Goal	Key Competencies	Illustrative Activities
Develop gross and fine motor skills	Runs, climbs, balances, writes legibly, manipulates tools	Outdoor games, clay modelling, colouring, threading beads
Enhance bodily awareness and spatial orientation	Moves confidently in a group, shows balance and coordination	Obstacle courses, musical chairs, dance
Promote health and hygiene practices	Understands need for clean food, exercise, and rest	Handwashing routines, storytelling around hygiene, health charts
Build stamina and strength for learning	Can sit for tasks, carry materials, participate actively	Rhythmic exercises, short physical tasks between lessons

Teachers must adopt developmentally appropriate pedagogy that supports and enhances physical development which may include intentionally integrating ‘movement and play’ into everyday learning experiences. To foster both gross and fine motor skills, teachers should focus on children’s abilities to run, climb, balance, write legibly, and handle small tools. Activities such as outdoor games, clay modelling, colouring, and threading beads are particularly effective in promoting these skills. Another essential goal is to develop bodily awareness and spatial orientation. Children should be guided to move confidently within a group, maintain balance, and coordinate their movements. Engaging activities like obstacle courses, musical chairs, and dance can greatly support this development. Promoting health and hygiene practices is also a crucial aspect of physical development. Children should be made to learn the importance of clean food, regular exercise, and adequate rest. This can be reinforced through structured routines such as handwashing, storytelling about hygiene, and the use of visual aids like health charts. To ensure children are physically prepared for classroom learning, it is important to help them build stamina and strength. This includes developing the ability to sit through tasks, carry materials, and participate actively. Incorporating rhythmic exercises and brief movement-based transitions between lessons can help achieve this.

Further, in inclusive classrooms, activity-based teaching can be adapted to support children with disabilities like children who are unable to jump can be encouraged to sort objects or use hand gestures to indicate choices, while others might use alternative forms of participation.

Now, as a teacher, one must know how assessment in the physical domain is to be carried out. Observational, continuous, and child-friendly assessment strategies focusing on motor skill proficiency, participation and engagement, improvement over time and willingness to try new physical tasks must be used in the classrooms for which teachers can use anecdotal records, checklists, performance tasks, and peer feedback. You may study about the assessment tools in detail in the following chapters.

You are suggested to :

- Observe physical activities in a school setting
- Design simple motor skill activities aligned with curriculum goals
- Reflect on how physical activity influences student learning
- Plan an integrated lesson combining movement and subject content
- Conduct a mock observation and prepare a brief report on motor development



CHECK YOUR PROGRESS 4.1

1. Which of the following is a typical physical development milestone for children aged 3–5 years?
 - a) Writing in cursive
 - b) Balancing on one foot for a few seconds
 - c) Driving a bicycle with gears
 - d) Complex sports strategies
2. At what age do most children begin to show improved coordination and control in activities such as running and jumping?
 - a) 1–2 years
 - b) 3–5 years
 - c) 6–8 years
 - d) 9–11 years

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3. What is a key feature of assessing physical development in children at the foundational and preparatory stages?
 - a) Conducting written tests on exercise benefits
 - b) Focusing on competition and rankings
 - c) Using continuous, observational, and child-friendly strategies
 - d) Giving weekly grades based on speed and strength

Ans: 1-b; 2-c; 3-c

4.3.2 Cognitive Development

Cognitive development refers to the growth of a child's ability to think and reason that involves skills such as perception, memory, language, attention, problem-solving, and logical thinking. For children (ages 3–11), this period is marked by a gradual transition from intuitive and sensory-based thinking to more logical and organized thought processes lays the foundation for future learning. Hence, teachers play a critical role in providing age-appropriate challenges that nurture curiosity, reasoning, and creativity.

Let us go through a case study and understand it in detail:

Case

“Rekha (aged 10) struggles to grasp age-appropriate academic concepts, particularly in mathematics and reading comprehension. She often needs instructions to be repeated multiple times and has difficulty following multi-step directions. Her ability to concentrate is limited, and she gets easily distracted during class activities. In group tasks, Rekha tends to rely heavily on peers, and she struggles with tasks that require reasoning, classification, or prediction.”

Rekha's case reflects the importance of early identification and support for children who show signs of slow cognitive development. With a nurturing environment, individualized learning strategies, and collaboration, children with cognitive delays can continue to grow at their own pace and participate positively in school life. For this, a teacher needs to be aware of the cognitive development pattern and age-appropriate characteristics.

Children of 3-11 years typically fall within Piaget's Pre-Operational and Concrete Operational Stage. As we have already read all the stages of Piaget's cognitive development theory in B.Ed., we may not go into details now, but shall revisit the characteristics of cognitive development focusing 3-11 years of children.

Table 4.2: Cognitive Development Characteristics of Pre-Operational and Concrete Operational Stages

Pre-Operational Stage	Concrete Operational Stage
• Symbolic thinking (using words, images, or objects to represent something else). • Egocentrism (difficulty in seeing perspectives other than their own). • Imaginative play and animism (believing objects have feelings or intentions). • Limited understanding of logic and cause-effect. • Difficulty with conservation (understanding that quantity doesn't change with appearance).	• Begin to think more logically and concretely. • Understand concepts like conservation, classification, and seriation (ordering objects). • Improved perspective-taking. • Better understanding of cause and effect. • Still need hands-on experiences to fully understand abstract concepts.

Children undergo a remarkable cognitive transformation as they transition from the Preoperational Stage to the Concrete Operational Stage. In the early years (3–7 years), children primarily think in symbolic and imaginative ways. They are egocentric, often understanding the world only from their own perspective, and struggle with logical reasoning. Their learning is shaped by play, imitation, and language use, but their thoughts are still governed by perception rather than logic. As children grow into 7–11 age range, they gradually move into the Concrete Operational Stage. This transition is marked by emergence of logical thinking, ability to understand conservation of quantity, classification, and ability to consider others' viewpoints. They become more capable of using reasoning to solve problems, especially when dealing with real or tangible situations. This cognitive shift does not happen overnight but unfolds gradually, influenced by experiences, social interaction, and guided learning. For teachers, understanding this transition is crucial to designing developmentally appropriate

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activities that nurture reasoning, memory, and problem-solving while providing the right balance of concrete experiences and opportunities for abstract thinking. Also, based on the features of different stages, NEP 2020 stresses a learner-centred, competency-based curriculum that ensures conceptual understanding and cognitive flexibility from an early age.

Now, let us discuss about the curricular goals and learning outcomes aligned with NEP (2020):

Table 4.3: Curricular Goals, Learning Outcomes and Aligned Domain with reference to Cognitive Development

Stage	Curricular Goals	Key Learning Outcomes
Foundational Stage (Ages 3–8)	• Develop thinking and reasoning through exploration and play • Enhance observation, attention, and memory • Foster early mathematical concepts (number, shape, quantity) • Promote scientific thinking through observation and inquiry • Build executive function skills (focus, planning, persistence)	• Identifies patterns, similarities, and differences • Classifies and groups objects by attributes • Counts, compares quantities, and uses numbers in everyday situations • Uses spatial vocabulary (e.g., near, far, inside) • Engages in simple problem solving during stories or games • Follows multi-step instructions and stays focused

Stage	Curricular Goals	Key Learning Outcomes
Preparatory Stage (Ages 8–11)	- Strengthen conceptual understanding across subjects - Support transition from concrete to abstract thinking - Develop logical, analytical, and inferential reasoning - Encourage interdisciplinary thinking and connections - Enhance problem-solving and decision-making skills	- Applies basic operations to solve real life math problems - Draws conclusions based on data and evidence - Interprets information using maps, charts, or timelines - Compares and contrasts information from varied sources - Demonstrates planning, organizing, and task completion - Asks thoughtful questions and explores multiple solutions

These learning outcomes guide teachers in designing lessons that are concept-driven, contributing to cognitive development. To achieve the above-mentioned goals, a teacher must organize structured learning experiences which involve growth across several key areas that support their ability to learn, think, and understand the world. The important areas are attention and concentration, where children gradually learn to focus on tasks and resist distractions. Activities such as story-listening and playing board games help in strengthening these skills. Memory, both short-term and long-term, plays a vital role in helping children recall facts, follow instructions, and apply concepts, such as remembering the steps to solve a math problem. As children grow, they develop logical reasoning, enabling them to compare, infer, and deduce; this is supported through activities like sorting shapes or solving puzzles. Problem-solving skills also emerge, allowing children to identify challenges and experiment with strategies to find solutions, for example, through math word problems or simple science tasks. The development of language and comprehension helps children understand, express, and communicate ideas more clearly, as seen in story retelling or responding to questions. These interconnected cognitive abilities form the foundation for academic success and everyday problem-solving. You may observe some of the effective teaching strategies for cognitive development in the figure 4.2

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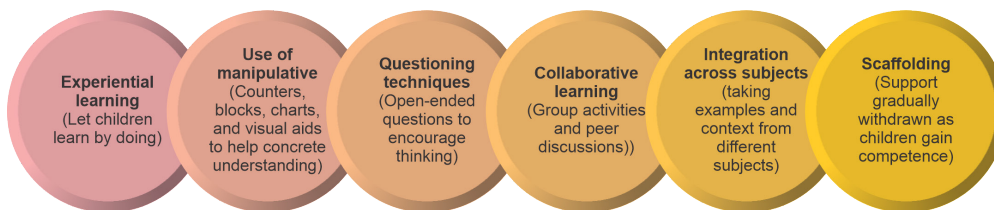


Fig. 4.2: Effective teaching strategies for cognitive development

You must understand that assessing cognitive development in students requires a shift from traditional rote-based evaluation to more meaningful, process-oriented approaches. The National Curriculum Framework for School Education, (NCFSE, 2023) emphasizes that assessment should be formative, continuous, and centred on constructive feedback. This perspective encourages teachers to focus on how students think and process information, rather than merely assessing what they can recall. In alignment with this philosophy, tools like, concept mapping allows students to visually represent their understanding and relationships between concepts. Oral questioning can also be used to promote real-time cognitive engagement and critical thinking. Further, observational checklists help teachers systematically track developmental indicators during learning activities. Portfolios of student work provide longitudinal insight into a learner's progress, reflecting both growth and depth of understanding. Together, these tools create a comprehensive and reflective assessment environment that nurtures deeper learning.

You are suggested to

- Observe children's play to identify cognitive milestones and areas in need of support
- Design structured play activities that include puzzles, memory games, sorting tasks, storytelling with open-ended questions, building blocks, and science experiments.
- Organize inquiry circles for the students investigating a theme or a topic.



CHECK YOUR PROGRESS 4.2

1. Which of the following is a key characteristic of the Pre-Operational Stage of cognitive development?

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- a) Logical reasoning and conservation
 - b) Understanding of classification and seriation
 - c) Symbolic thinking and egocentrism
 - d) Abstract thinking and hypothesis testing
2. According to Piaget, what cognitive change typically occurs in children within the age group of 7 to 11 years?
- a) Increased egocentrism and symbolic thinking
 - b) Transition to abstract and hypothetical reasoning
 - c) Emergence of logical thinking and understanding of conservation
 - d) Complete reliance on imaginative play for learning
3. Which of the following assessment tools is specifically used to visually represent a student's understanding and the relationships between concepts?
- a) Oral questioning
 - b) Observational checklist
 - c) Concept mapping
 - d) Written tests

Ans: 1-c; 2-c; 3-c

4.3.3 Socio-Emotional Development

The socio-emotional domain refers to the development of a child's ability to understand and manage emotions, establish healthy relationships, show empathy, make responsible decisions, and handle social situations effectively. Children of the stages, we are focusing at in this unit, are generally marked by characteristics involving forming their self-concept, learning to cooperate, and experiencing a wide range of emotions as they transition from home-centred to peer-influenced environments leading to increased emotional awareness, relationship skills, and moral understanding.

Please read the following case studies and observe the difference in the characteristics of the behaviour of children of different stages:

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Case 1:

“Meera is a cheerful 5-year-old girl in a kindergarten classroom. She enjoys singing rhymes and participating in group activities. However, when her favourite toy is taken by a classmate, she bursts into tears and finds it difficult to express why she is upset. Her teacher gently comforts her and helps her use words like “I am sad” or “I want to play with it too.” Meera is still learning how to share and take turns. While she shows kindness—like offering a crayon to a friend—her understanding of others’ feelings is limited and guided mostly by adult prompts. She needs consistent reassurance and support to feel emotionally secure.”

Socio-Emotional Highlights of children of age 3–8 years:

- Expresses basic emotions but struggles with emotional regulation
- Learns to share and cooperate, but still egocentric at times
- Shows emerging empathy with adult guidance
- Needs close adult support for conflict resolution and self-soothing

Case 2:

“Neel is a confident and thoughtful student in class 5. He works well in groups, often taking on leadership roles. During a group project, when two of his teammates argue over who should present, Neel steps in to mediate, suggesting a fair turn-taking strategy. He is able to recognize when a peer is feeling left out and invites them to join in. He takes responsibility for his actions and is developing a strong sense of fairness and justice. Neel is also beginning to compare himself with peers and values praise from teachers and friends, which shapes his self-esteem.”

Socio-Emotional Highlights of Children of Age 8–11 years (Age 8–11):

- Greater emotional control and ability to express complex feelings
- Strong peer bonds, with growing ability to resolve conflicts independently
- Increased empathy and perspective-taking
- Developing self-concept and moral reasoning

Now, let us know more about other characteristic features of the socio-emotional development of children of age group 3-11 years:

Table 4.4: Characteristic features of socio-emotional development of children of age group 3-11 years

Foundational Stage (Ages 3–8 Years)	Preparatory Stage (Ages 8–11 Years)
• Self-awareness begins to emerge: Children start recognizing their own feelings and preferences (e.g., “I am happy”, “I don’t like noise”). • Managing emotions is a learning process: They may struggle with regulating strong emotions like anger or frustration, needing adult support and modelling. • Attachment and trust are central: Strong emotional bonds with parents, teachers, and caregivers help children feel secure and confident. • Peer interaction begins: Children move from parallel play (playing side-by-side) to cooperative play, learning to take turns and share. • Empathy starts to develop: Though still egocentric at times, they begin to notice others’ feelings and may offer comfort.	• Greater emotional control: Children begin to manage impulses better and can articulate complex emotions such as jealousy, embarrassment, or pride. • Stronger peer relationships: Friendships become deeper and more stable, and peer influence grows. Group belonging and cooperation are highly valued. • Moral development progresses: Children begin to understand fairness, rules, and responsibility. They show concern for justice and right/wrong. • Perspective-taking improves: They become capable of seeing situations from others’ points of view, which strengthens empathy and reduces conflicts. • Self-esteem becomes important: Children seek recognition for their efforts and achievements and may compare themselves with peers.

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There are a few key aspects of socio-emotional development that every teacher must be aware of:

Table 4.5: Key Aspects of Socio-Emotional Development

Aspect	Foundational Stage (3–8 years)	Preparatory Stage (8–11 years)
Emotional Awareness	Recognizes and names basic emotions like happy, sad, angry	Identifies complex emotions like frustration, pride, embarrassment
Emotional Regulation	Begins to manage feelings; uses basic coping strategies	Uses reasoning to manage emotions; reflects on emotional responses
Self-Concept & Confidence	Builds positive self-image through praise and routine	Develops personal identity and growing independence
Relationship Building	Forms trust-based bonds with teachers and peers	Builds deeper friendships based on mutual respect and trust
Empathy and Respect	Shows concern for others; learns to share and care	Understands perspectives of others; shows fairness and empathy
Social Interaction	Engages in cooperative play; learns turn-taking and simple rules	Works in teams; participates in group decisions and cooperation
Conflict Resolution	Resolves conflicts with adult help; uses words to express needs	Manages peer conflicts using communication and negotiation
Moral Development	Understands basic concepts of right and wrong through modelling	Begins to reason about fairness, justice, and ethical behaviour
Communication Skills	Learns to express feelings and needs using simple language	Expresses emotions and opinions with more clarity and empathy
Learning Environment Need	Needs a secure, predictable, nurturing setting	Requires a safe, inclusive environment that supports autonomy

Let us now examine the curricular goals and essential competencies related to socio- emotional development that teachers should be mindful of while engaging with students aged 3 to 11 years in the classroom.

Table 4.6: Curricular Goals, Competencies and Learning Outcomes related to Socio-Emotional Development

Curricular Goal	Competency	Learning Outcome
Develop emotional resilience and empathy	Recognizes and names feelings, shows care for others	Shares resource, identifies emotions in stories or other contexts.
Foster effective interpersonal communication	Listens to others, speaks with clarity and kindness	Participates in group activities, asks for help politely
Encourage conflict resolution and decision-making	Solves peer issues with adult support	Resolves differences through dialogue
Promote self-confidence and positive identity	Expresses opinions respectfully	Presents ideas in class, talks about personal experiences

Given that socio-emotional development should be seamlessly integrated into daily classroom practices, it is important for teachers to adopt specific pedagogical strategies in regular teaching. Teachers play a vital role by modelling positive behaviours such as kindness, patience, and fairness, which children often imitate. Activities like circle time and class meetings provide a safe space where children can openly express their feelings and discuss challenges they face. On the other hand, storytelling and role play allow children to explore a range of emotions and develop empathy by relating to characters and situations. Further, a teacher may employ group activities that promote cooperation, teamwork, and shared responsibility, helping children learn to work together. Tools such as emotion cards or mood charts are effective in helping children recognize, label, and understand their own emotions. Additionally, using positive reinforcement to acknowledge effort, good behaviour, and emotional growth helps build self-esteem and encourages children to continue developing their emotional and social skills.

A teacher must also be aware of how socio-emotional skills of students need to be assessed. Assessment of socio-emotional development in children should be thoughtful, supportive, and focused on understanding individual needs rather

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than labelling or judging. Tools such as anecdotal records allow teachers to document specific observations of a child's behaviour and emotional responses in real situations. Another tool is behaviour checklists which help track patterns over time, offering insights into social skills, emotional regulation, and interaction styles. Teacher may also use peer feedback, such as asking "Who is helpful to you?", that provides valuable perspectives from classmates and can reveal how a child is perceived within the social group. Further, reflective journals or drawings, particularly for older children, have been found to be encouraging self-expression and process their emotions and experiences. Additionally, teacher reflections on interaction patterns offer a deeper understanding of classroom dynamics and individual emotional needs. Overall, these methods should be used to celebrate children's strengths and provide gentle, personalised support to foster healthy emotional and social development. Along with this, a teacher plays a critical role in creating a socially and emotionally supportive classroom environment. Encouraging inclusivity and respect for all backgrounds helps children feel valued and accepted, regardless of their culture, language, or abilities. Addressing bullying, teasing, or exclusion promptly is essential to ensure every child feels safe and protected in the learning space.

You are suggested to:

- Observe student interactions and recording social behaviours
- Plan and facilitate a circle time or SEL (social-emotional learning) activity
- Design a classroom rule chart with students
- Reflect on a case study involving a child's emotional or behavioural challenges
- Prepare a simple socio-emotional learning lesson plan (e.g., teaching empathy using a story)



CHECK YOUR PROGRESS 4.3

1. Which of the following is a key socio-emotional milestone for children aged 8–11 years?
 - a) Parallel play and emerging empathy
 - b) Strong attachment to caregivers

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- c) Articulating complex emotions like jealousy and embarrassment
 - d) Recognizing simple emotions like happiness or anger
2. According to NEP 2020 and NCFSE (2023), which of the following should schools focus on to support socio-emotional development?
- a) Emphasizing academic competition
 - b) Promoting emotional intelligence and healthy relationships
 - c) Reducing playtime to focus on academics
 - d) Teaching only through textbooks
3. At Preparatory Stage (ages 8–11), children typically demonstrate which of the following socio-emotional abilities?
- a) Recognizing basic emotions like happy and sad
 - b) Relying on adults to resolve all peer conflicts
 - c) Managing emotions using reasoning and reflecting on responses
 - d) Expressing needs using only simple language

Ans: 1-c; 2-b; 3-c

4.3.4 Moral Development

Moral development refers to how children learn to distinguish right from wrong, develop values, and build a sense of fairness, justice, honesty, empathy, and responsibility. Children go through distinct stages of moral development as they grow, progressing from a self-centred understanding of right and wrong to a more socially aware and principled perspective. These stages have been extensively studied by theorists such as Jean Piaget and Lawrence Kohlberg which we have already read in B.Ed. Here, we would be revisiting stages covering children of 3-11 years.

Pre-Moral Stage (0–5 years): In early childhood, children have little understanding of rules or morality. Their behaviour is guided mainly by immediate desires, fear of punishment, and the reactions of adults.

Heteronomous Morality / Pre-Conventional Stage (5–9 years): At this stage, children see rules as fixed and absolute, imposed by authority figures. Morality is based on avoiding punishment or gaining rewards. They believe in “right” and “wrong” as outcomes of consequences, not intentions.

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Autonomous Morality / Conventional Stage (9–12 years): Children begin to understand that rules can be flexible and are created for mutual benefit. They start considering intentions behind actions and value approval from others. Morality is increasingly based on social norms, fairness, and maintaining relationships.

In addition to the understanding of these stages, a few key aspects of moral development must also be known to a teacher:

Table 4.7: Key aspects of Moral Development

Aspect	Description
Understanding Right and Wrong	Children gradually learn to distinguish acceptable from unacceptable behaviour based on consequences, adult guidance, and later, social norms.
Rule Awareness	Younger children see rules as fixed, while older ones begin to understand that rules serve social purposes and can be adjusted.
Consequences and Intentions	Early on, morality is based on consequences; by age 8–11, children begin to consider intentions behind actions.
Fairness and Justice	Children develop a strong sense of fairness; around ages 6–11, they become more concerned with equity and justice.
Empathy and Perspective-Taking	Moral development is closely tied to emotional development; children begin to understand and care about others' feelings.
Respect for Rules and Authority	Young children respect authority out of fear; older children begin to understand social roles and follow rules to maintain order.
Moral Reasoning	Shifts from “What will happen to me?” to “Is it fair for everyone?” and “What is the right thing to do?”
Honesty and Truthfulness	Children learn the value of honesty, often through consequences and adult modelling.
Responsibility and Accountability	By age 10–11, children start accepting responsibility for their actions and understand the importance of making amends.
Role of Modelling and Reinforcement	Teachers' and adults' behaviours significantly influence moral learning through role modelling, praise, and correction.

Let us now examine the curricular goals and essential competencies related to moral development as suggested by NCFSE (2023) that teachers must be mindful of:

Table 4.8: Curricular goals, Competencies and Learning Outcomes related to Moral Development

Curricular Goal	Competency	Learning Outcome
Develop understanding of right and wrong	Distinguishes between appropriate and inappropriate behaviour	Follows class rules, identifies fair and unfair actions
Promote honesty and integrity	Demonstrates truthfulness and takes responsibility for actions	Admits mistakes, avoids lying or blaming others
Foster empathy and respect for others	Understands others' feelings and viewpoints	Shows kindness, avoids hurtful language or behaviour
Encourage fairness and justice	Recognizes the need for equal treatment and fairness in play/work	Waits for turn, includes others, accepts outcomes of group decisions
Support respect for rules and authority	Follows rules and understands their purpose	Adheres to class norms, respects adult directions
Encourage ethical decision-making	Makes choices considering consequences and others' well-being	Chooses to help, shares resource, avoids harmful behaviour intentionally
Cultivate responsibility and accountability	Takes responsibility for personal and shared tasks	Completes assigned duties, acknowledges the impact of actions on others
Promote community and cooperation	Works collaboratively and contributes to a positive environment	Participates in group work, supports peers, resolves conflicts with support

To achieve moral development goals and learning outcomes, teachers must create value-rich classrooms where ethics are not taught in isolation but are embedded

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in everyday experiences. One effective approach is using storytelling with moral questions, where folk tales, fables, and real-life scenarios invite children to reflect on values and ethical choices. The others are role-play and dramatization that allow students to enact dilemmas and explore resolutions, making moral concepts tangible and relatable. Assigning classroom responsibilities, such as rotating roles like line leader or plant caretaker, fosters a sense of accountability and shared duty. Most importantly, teachers must consistently model moral behaviour themselves, demonstrating fairness, kindness, and integrity, so that children can learn through observation and example.

In the context of Continuous and Comprehensive Evaluation (CCE), assessing moral growth requires a thoughtful and nurturing approach rather than traditional grading. Moral development is best understood through consistent observation, reflection, and support. For example, anecdotal records are useful for noting specific examples of moral decisions made by students in everyday situations. Moreover, self-assessment allows children to reflect on their own behaviour and understand the impact of their actions. In addition to this, peer feedback offers valuable insights into how children are perceived by their classmates, promoting self-awareness and social learning. This holistic approach ensures that moral growth is encouraged as a continuous, lived experience in the classroom.

You are suggested to:

- Observe children's moral behaviours and interactions
- Plan a storytelling session around a moral theme with follow-up discussion
- Design a simple classroom value chart or responsibility roster
- Create a reflective worksheet for students on "What does being fair mean?"



CHECK YOUR PROGRESS 4.4

1. According to the stages of moral development, Arjun's behaviour in the case study (lying, blaming others, and showing little guilt) most likely indicates:

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- a) Autonomous morality based on fairness and intentions
 - b) Pre-moral thinking based on empathy
 - c) Heteronomous morality focused on avoiding punishment
 - d) A delay or concern in moral development that may require intervention
2. Which of the following best reflects the National Education Policy (NEP) 2020's approach to moral development in children?
- a) Teaching morality as a separate weekly subject
 - b) Using punishment to ensure moral behaviour
 - c) Integrating moral values throughout all teaching and learning experiences
 - d) Focusing only on academic achievement and competition
3. Which of the following classroom practices best supports the development of responsibility and accountability in children aged 3–11 years?
- a) Giving marks for moral values in weekly tests
 - b) Assigning rotating classroom roles like plant caretaker or line leader
 - c) Punishing students publicly for moral mistakes
 - d) Encouraging silent reflection without any real-life application

Ans: 1-d; 2-c; 3-b

4.3.5 Language Development

Language development is central to a child's ability to communicate, think, learn, and interact socially. It forms the foundation for literacy, academic achievement, and cognitive growth. At the foundational stage, children make significant progress in understanding, speaking, reading, and writing language. And, this stage is not limited to mastering vocabulary or grammar, it is about enabling expression, comprehension, and connection.

Let us explore the key characteristics of language development focusing the foundational and preparatory stages:

Perspectives of Child Development**Notes****Ages 3–5**

- There is rapid vocabulary growth (from about 900 to 2,500+ words).
- Child uses full sentences of 4–6 words; begins to use compound and complex sentences.
- Child applies basic grammar rules, though some over generalizations occur.
- Child starts telling simple stories with a beginning, middle, and end.
- Most speech is understandable, though some sounds may still be developing.
- Frequently asks “why” and “how” questions, showing curiosity and reasoning.
- Begins to understand turn-taking, greetings, and polite expressions.

Ages 6–8

- Vocabulary expands to 5,000+ words; learns new words from reading, conversations, and school.
- Child attains mastery of most grammatical structures (tense, plurals, pronouns, etc.).
- Learns to read with increasing fluency; begins to decode unfamiliar words and comprehend basic texts.
- Starts writing complete sentences and short paragraphs; begins to organize ideas.
- Follows multi-step instructions; engages in more detailed and purposeful conversations.
- Can retell stories in sequence and create original narratives with more structure.

Ages 9–11

- Vocabulary expands to 10,000+ words; includes academic and subject-specific vocabulary.

- Child uses more advanced sentence structures (e.g., relative clauses, passive voice).
- Child understands figurative language, main ideas, inference, and themes in more complex texts.
- Child writes multi-paragraph compositions with logical flow, varied sentence structures, and appropriate grammar and punctuation.
- Child begins using language to argue, justify opinions, and debate.
- Child adjusts speech for different audiences and contexts; understands humour, sarcasm, and non-literal language.

The NEP (2020) and the NCFSE (2023) emphasize a holistic approach to language learning with clearly defined aims. In the domain of listening, students learn to attentively receive and interpret spoken messages through activities such as story listening and following oral instructions. Speaking skills are nurtured by encouraging learners to clearly express their thoughts, ideas, and emotions through show-and-tell sessions, class discussions, and role play. In the reading domain, students work on decoding and comprehending written texts using strategies like shared reading, reading aloud, and engaging in phonics games. Writing skills are developed as learners progress from writing simple sentences to paragraphs and short compositions through activities such as diary writing, guided writing, and creative exercises. Lastly, a focus on vocabulary and grammar helps children use accurate word forms and sentence structures, supported by interactive tasks like word games, cloze passages, and language puzzles. Together, these domains foster comprehensive language proficiency in a dynamic and engaging manner.

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You are suggested to:

- Observe classroom language practices and identify opportunities for improvement
- Create a print-rich corner with multilingual labels and age-appropriate books
- Plan and conduct a storytelling session with follow-up language activities
- Design a reading comprehension worksheet for a short passage
- Prepare a language game that promotes vocabulary and sentence formation

4.4 ROLE OF DIFFERENT STAKEHOLDERS IN DEVELOPMENT OF LEARNERS AT FOUNDATIONAL AND PREPARATORY STAGE

During early years, children acquire essential skills and knowledge that form the foundation for future learning. Achieving holistic development requires the active participation of a variety of stakeholders, each playing a crucial role in providing support, guidance, and resources. These stakeholders include parents, teachers, educational administrators, community members, and policymakers. By understanding the strengths of these different groups, we can ensure that children receive the necessary tools to thrive both academically and socially. In the following section, we are going to focus on the role of family, peer and school in development of children.

4.4.1 Role of Family in Development

At the initial stage, children experience rapid development across physical, cognitive, socio-emotional, and moral domains. While schools provide structured learning, home environment, especially the role of family remains central to shaping children's values, attitudes, learning behaviours, and overall well-being. Now, let us observe the following case studies and understand the role of family in development of a child.

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CASE 1	CASE 2
<i>“Aryan, a 7-year-old boy, thrives in an environment where his parents, Priya and Raj, are actively involved in his development. From an early age, they created a learning-rich home environment, prioritizing reading and interactive learning. Priya and Raj foster Aryan’s curiosity, creativity, and critical thinking by engaging him in creative activities, providing academic support, and teaching him problem-solving skills.”</i>	<i>“Ravi, an 8-year-old boy, experiences limited family support, affecting his academic and emotional development. His mother, Sita, works for long hours and is unable to guide him with homework. As a result, Ravi struggles academically, lacks focus, and becomes frustrated with his schoolwork.”</i>

The above given two case studies clearly illustrate the significant influence families have on a child’s overall development. Policy documents like NEP (2020) and NCFSE (2023) emphasize that families provide the first and most crucial learning environment, laying the foundation for early language acquisition, cognitive growth, and the development of lifelong learning attitudes. Moreover, through everyday interactions, families encourage curiosity, creativity, and self-confidence, helping children become active and engaged learners.

The table below highlights key developmental domains and specific ways in which families contribute:

Table 4.9: Developmental Domain and Family’s Role

Developmental Domain	Family’s Role	Examples
Physical Development	Providing nutrition, routine, rest, and play	Ensuring daily meals and outdoor playtime
Cognitive Development	Engaging in conversations, asking questions, encouraging exploration	Helping with homework, telling stories
Language Development	Using rich oral language at home, reading aloud	Conversations, songs, shared reading
Socio-Emotional Development	Modelling empathy, resolving conflict, supporting emotional needs	Teaching sharing, responding to child’s fears

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Moral Development	Setting boundaries, modelling honesty and respect	Discouraging lying, encouraging apology and forgiveness
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While families play a vital role in child's development, it is important to acknowledge that not all families have equal access to resources, time, or support systems. Many caregivers may face challenges such as limited literacy, economic hardship, or lack of educational materials at home. Some children come from single-parent households or families dealing with health and social difficulties, while others may be raised in environments with differing cultural or educational expectations.

Now let us see!

In order to effectively engage families in child's development, what specific pedagogical practices should a teacher adopt that foster collaboration and support?

Building relationships with parents or caregivers is crucial for creating a positive partnership. Teachers may encourage open and respectful communication, ensuring that families feel heard and valued. As a teacher, you may also suggest simple strategies to parents for creating a support system at home by carrying out activities such as reading together or discussing the day's events. Additionally, we must understand that parent-teacher meetings must go beyond academics, addressing children's behaviour, interests, and emotional health to give a holistic view of child's development. Teacher must invite parents in classroom events, storytelling sessions, or cultural celebrations which may help in building a sense of community and connection among parents and children. Teachers may also share helpful resources or ideas through digital social groups, activity sheets, or even community visits, ensuring families to play meaningful role in nurturing child's learning journey. In addition to engaging families in the learning process, teachers can engage parents in assessments like encouraging parents to share home-based observations and samples of work done at home that may make assessment a collaborative process, not merely a report card.

You are suggested to:

- Observe classroom language practices and identify opportunities for improvement
- Design a parent communication plan for their classroom
- Create a home activity sheet for reinforcing a learning concept (e.g., reading log, family interview)



CHECK YOUR PROGRESS 4.5

1. According to the NEP (2020) and NCFSE (2023), what is the role of parents and caregivers in a child's learning journey?
 - a) Parents are responsible only for their child's emotional needs.
 - b) Parents and caregivers should act as co-educators, supporting early learning in multiple developmental domains.
 - c) Parents are only responsible for their child's physical development.
 - d) Parents should not be involved in the educational process.
2. Which of the following is NOT an example of how families contribute to a child's development?
 - a) Modelling empathy and resolving conflicts in socio-emotional development
 - b) Setting boundaries and modelling honesty in moral development
 - c) Limiting the use of oral language at home in language development
 - d) Providing nutrition, rest, and play in physical development

Ans: 1-b; 2-c

4.4.2 Role of Peers in Development

Peers are individuals who are of the same age, status, or ability level within a specific group or context. As children transition from the home environment into the school setting, peers become central to their social, emotional, moral, cognitive, and language development. For teachers, understanding the power of peer influence and how to use it constructively is vital for designing effective,

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age-appropriate pedagogical practices and managing inclusive learning environments.

The NEP (2020) emphasizes the importance of peer collaboration as a fundamental aspect of the learning process. It encourages the use of diverse teaching strategies like peer tutoring, group projects, and cooperative learning, ensuring that every child benefits from positive interactions with their peers.

Now, let us observe the major domains of development where peers may influence and assist in development:

Table 4.10: Developmental Domains and Peer Influence

Domain	Peer Influence	Examples
Cognitive	Peer explanations enhance understanding; children learn by observing and interacting with others	Group problem-solving in math, learning new strategies
Language	Peer talk supports vocabulary and language structures	Conversations during play, partner reading
Socio-emotional	Learning to cooperate, share, and resolve conflicts Gaining self-awareness through group roles and peer feedback	Taking turns in games, expressing feelings Leading a group activity, receiving peer praise
Moral	Developing fairness, justice, empathy, and responsibility	Standing up for a friend, negotiating rules in play

To harness the benefits of peer learning, pedagogical practices like pair and group work for reading, problem-solving, and collaborative projects, as well as peer tutoring, where older or more capable students support others, may be used in the classrooms. Circle time offers a space for sharing thoughts and listening, while role play, and dramatization build empathy and teamwork. Additionally, buddy systems can pair students to support inclusion, especially for new, shy or children with special needs. The teacher's role is to guide, observe, and scaffold peer interactions, ensuring that they are positive, respectful, and productive. Teachers can also assess learning through peer feedback tools, like simple reflections, checklists, reflective journals that may provide insight into students' experiences during group activities. These assessments offer valuable information about interpersonal skills, leadership, and empathy, all critical aspects of a child's development.

While peer relationships can be highly beneficial, they can also present challenges such as exclusion, conflict, or competition. Teachers must take proactive steps to manage these dynamics by establishing clear norms for respectful behaviour.

You are suggested to:

- Observe peer interactions in a real or simulated classroom setting
- Plan and implement a group learning activity, documenting student interactions
- Role-play a situation involving peer conflict and resolution
- Create a peer learning plan (e.g., buddy reading, peer review)



CHECK YOUR PROGRESS 4.6

1. According to the NEP (2020), how does peer collaboration contribute to the learning process?
 - a) Peer collaboration only benefits language development.
 - b) Peer collaboration is essential for developing social, emotional, cognitive, and moral skills.
 - c) Peer collaboration should be avoided as it distracts from teacher-led instruction.
 - d) Peer collaboration only contributes to physical development.
2. Which of the following is an example of peer influence on socio-emotional development?
 - a) Partner reading to improve language skills
 - b) Learning to cooperate, share, and resolve conflicts during games
 - c) Gaining self-awareness through peer feedback
 - d) Solving math problems together in a group

Ans: 1-b; 2-b

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4.4.3 Role of School in Development

Just like parents and peers, school also plays an important role in the overall development of a child by providing a structured, nurturing, and stimulating environment that supports growth across multiple developmental domains. Before going further, let's observe the following case study, reflecting the role of school in development of students:

CASE

Zain, a 10-year-old student in Class 5, lived in a small town and attended a government school. From a young age, Zain showed curiosity about how things work and enjoyed asking questions. However, he was also shy and hesitant to speak in large groups. His parents, both working, provided basic support at home but relied heavily on the school for his academic and social growth. His class teacher noticed his interest in science and began encouraging him through simple experiments and project-based learning. Recognizing his shyness, the teacher also involved him in group activities and role-plays, slowly building his confidence and socio-emotional skills.

So, do you think, through teacher support and a positive school climate, Zain began to thrive not just academically but also socially and emotionally? This case illustrates how a school, by offering inclusive and developmentally appropriate experiences, can significantly influence the holistic growth of a child.

The NEP (2020) and the frameworks like the NCFFS (2022) and the NCFSE (2023) recognize schools as key institutions in ensuring the holistic development of every child. These policies highlight that schools are not just places for academic instruction but nurturing spaces where children grow across all developmental domains. Schools are expected to provide safe, engaging, and flexible learning environments that support each child's curiosity, self-expression, and confidence. Further, NCFFS (2022) reinforces the idea that schools must support the child's natural learning pace through age-appropriate pedagogies and materials.

Let us know more about the major developmental domains where schools significantly contribute:

Table 4.11: Developmental Domains and Role of School

Developmental Domains	Role of School in Development (Ages 3–11 Years)
Physical Development	Schools offer physical education and structured play, which are essential for motor skills development, healthy growth, and overall well-being.
Cognitive Development	Schools offer structured learning environments that stimulate curiosity, creativity, and problem-solving skills. The curriculum is designed to promote age-appropriate cognitive functions like memory, reasoning, language development, and numeracy. Art, music, dance, and drama are integral to the primary curriculum, allowing children to express themselves freely and build self-confidence.
Socio-Emotional Development	From early childhood onwards, school provides a social setting where children learn to collaborate, share, resolve conflicts, and develop empathy. Emotional learning programs are increasingly integrated to build resilience and mental health awareness.
Language Development	Language development is crucial at this stage, and schools play a key role by exposing children to diverse communication activities such as storytelling, debates, group discussions, and reading programs.
Moral Development	School is the first formal institution where children are introduced to values such as honesty, kindness, respect, and responsibility through both curricular and co-curricular means.
Social	In line with NEP 2020, schools are moving toward inclusive education, providing support to children with disabilities, children from marginalized communities, and first-generation learners. Schools act as bridges between families and the education system, organizing parent-teacher meetings, workshops, and community events to involve caregivers in children's growth.
Life Skills Development	Schools now include life skills such as first aid, digital literacy, environmental education, and disaster response training, especially post-COVID and climate change awareness.

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While addressing developmental needs, schools may encounter following challenges (refer to table 4.12):

Table 4.12: Challenges faced by Schools in Addressing Developmental Needs

Categories	Challenges Faced by Schools
Resource Limitations	• Lack of age-appropriate learning materials and infrastructure • Inadequate teacher-student ratio
Diverse Learning Needs	• Catering to children with varied developmental levels and learning styles • Inclusion of children with special needs without adequate support
Parental Engagement	• Limited involvement of parents due to lack of awareness, time, or education. Gaps in home-school communication
Emotional and Behavioural Issues	• Managing children with emotional difficulties, aggression, or low confidence • Limited access to counsellors or mental health support
Curriculum and Assessment Pressure	• Rigid curriculum that may not prioritize play, creativity, or emotional development • Overemphasis on academic assessments rather than holistic growth
Socio-Economic Disparities	• Children from underprivileged backgrounds may face poor nutrition, lack of school supplies, or absenteeism
Language and Cultural Diversity	• Multilingual classrooms where children may struggle with the language of instruction • Cultural differences affecting participation and comfort
Teacher Preparedness	• Teachers may lack training in child development, inclusive education, or activity-based pedagogy

To address these multifaceted challenges, schools may adopt a range of strategic interventions aimed at creating an inclusive, supportive, and holistic

learning environment. Investing in teacher training is crucial. Educators should be equipped with skills in early childhood development, inclusive practices, differentiated instruction, and activity-based learning to effectively engage diverse learners. Also, reducing the teacher-student ratio through additional hiring of support staff can enable more personalised attention. Schools should also strengthen home-school partnerships by conducting regular parent workshops, using accessible communication tools, and fostering a welcoming atmosphere for parental involvement. To support children's emotional well-being, integrating school counsellors, peer support systems, and socio-emotional learning programs can be beneficial. Adopting a flexible and balanced curriculum that values play, creativity, and life skills alongside academics ensures more holistic development. Additionally, schools should provide nutritional support, learning materials, and transportation assistance to students from underprivileged backgrounds to reduce inequities. Embracing multilingual and culturally responsive teaching methods helps bridge language and cultural gaps, making classrooms more inclusive. Collaborating with NGOs, community organizations, and government schemes can further expand the school's capacity to meet students' diverse needs effectively.



CHECK YOUR PROGRESS 4.7

1. How can schools support the holistic development of children?
 - a) By focusing only on academic achievements
 - b) By fostering collaboration, providing emotional support, and encouraging skill development across various domains
 - c) By discouraging social interactions among students
 - d) By concentrating solely on physical fitness activities

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4.5 LET US SUM UP

In this chapter, we explored some key concepts about children's development from ages 3 to 11 years:

1. Developmental Domains for Children (3–11 years):

- **Physical Growth:** Motor skills, coordination, and physical abilities are developing.
- **Cognitive Growth:** Children's problem-solving abilities, logical thinking, and intellectual development are expanding.
- **Socio-emotional Development:** Emotional regulation, empathy, and social skills take shape.
- **Moral Development:** Children begin to understand fairness, ethics, and moral reasoning.
- **Language Development:** Vocabulary, grammar, and communication skills grow stronger.

2. Roles of Different Stakeholders:

- **Teachers:** Create learning experiences that support children's development across various domains.
- **Families:** Offer emotional support and set the stage for early learning.
- **Peers:** Help develop social skills, empathy, and the ability to collaborate.
- **Schools:** Provide structured learning environments that nurture overall growth.



4.6 END EXERCISES

1. How can a teacher design a classroom activity that simultaneously supports cognitive, socio-emotional, and language development for children aged 3–11 years? Explain with an example.
2. In what ways can lack of collaboration among family, peers, and school hinder a child's holistic development? Support your answer with reasoning.

4.7 REFERENCES

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